

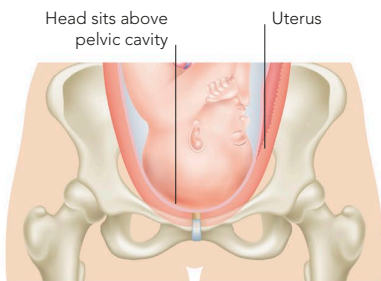
LABOUR

LABOUR USUALLY MEANS THE FULL PROCESS OF GIVING BIRTH. IT CAN BE DIVIDED INTO THREE PHASES OR STAGES: ONSET OF CONTRACTIONS TO FULL DILATION OF THE CERVIX; DELIVERY OF THE BABY; AND DELIVERY OF THE PLACENTA (AFTERBIRTH).

ENGAGEMENT

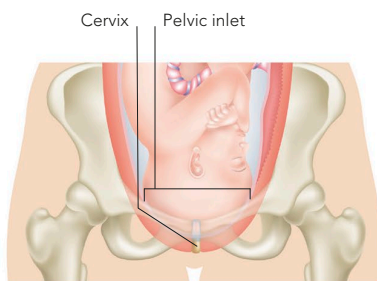
Towards the end of pregnancy, the part of the baby that will emerge first – usually the head – descends into the pelvic cavity. This is called engagement. Many women feel a sensation of dropping and “lightening” as it happens because the movement of the

baby lowers the upper uterus, relieving the pressure on the diaphragm and making it easier for the mother to breathe. Engagement usually takes place at about 36 weeks during a first pregnancy and at the onset of labour during subsequent pregnancies.



BEFORE THE HEAD ENGAGES

Before engagement, the top of the uterus reaches the breastbone. The baby's head has yet to pass through the inlet of the pelvis into the cavity.



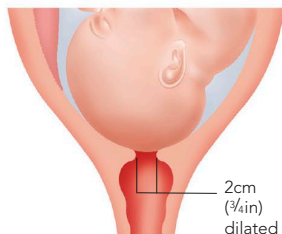
AFTER ENGAGEMENT

The baby's head descends into the pelvic cavity. The overall position of the uterus drops, and the baby's head rests against the uterine cervix.

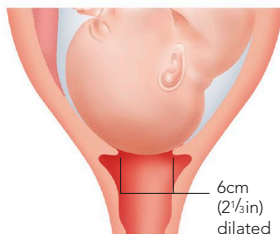
CERVICAL DILATION

Labour begins with the onset of regular, painful contractions, which dilate the cervix. These occur mainly in the upper uterus, which shortens and tightens, pulling and stretching the lower uterus

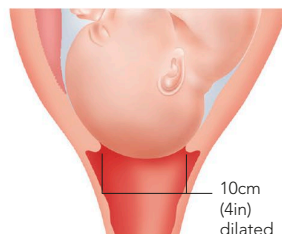
and cervix. For a first baby, the cervix dilates at about 1cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ in) per hour on average; progress is usually quicker for subsequent babies. In most women, the cervix is fully dilated when it opens to around 10cm (4in).



INITIAL DILATION



CERVIX WIDENS



FULLY DILATED